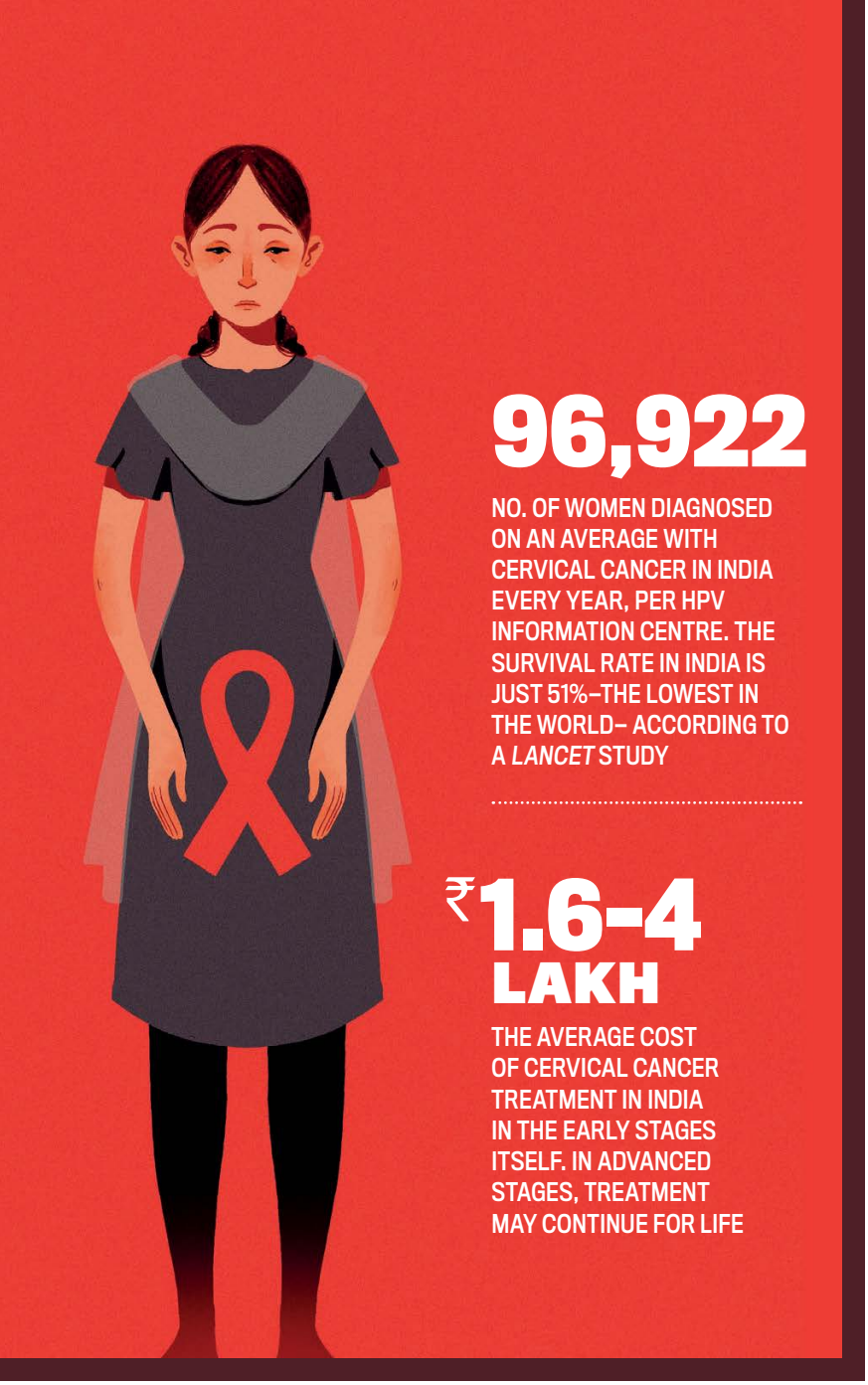


96,922

NO. OF WOMEN DIAGNOSED ON AN AVERAGE WITH CERVICAL CANCER IN INDIA EVERY YEAR, PER HPV INFORMATION CENTRE. THE SURVIVAL RATE IN INDIA IS JUST 51%–THE LOWEST IN THE WORLD– ACCORDING TO A *LANCET* STUDY

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THE AVERAGE COST OF CERVICAL CANCER TREATMENT IN INDIA IN THE EARLY STAGES ITSELF. IN ADVANCED STAGES, TREATMENT MAY CONTINUE FOR LIFE

Illustrations by SIDDHANT JUMDE

THE COST OF THE CERVICAL CANCER VACCINE HAS COME DOWN FROM AROUND Rs 4,000 A DOSE TO Rs 200-800. YET, IT HAS FOUND FEW TAKERS DUE TO MISINFORMATION ABOUT ITS SIDE-EFFECTS, WHICH ARE NEGLIGIBLE

dose. But with the Serum Institute of India (SII), Pune, launching a homegrown HPV shot, Cervavac, this year, that problem is eased too. The vaccine costs as low as Rs 200 to Rs 800 per dose, depending upon the provider. It was proven to have a high efficacy too—a double-dose shot taken six months apart and followed by a booster has been reported to have an antibody response that is 1,000 times higher than the baseline against all targeted HPV types and in all doses and age groups, and it works even against high-risk versions of the virus such as types 4, 6, 11, 16 and 18. Though recommended for girls under the age of 19, those who are already sexually active or over 19 can also take it after a screening test. And yet...

THE TRAGEDY CONTINUES

There have been barely any takers for the shot, thanks to the enduring stigma around female sexual health in India. "There is no point even storing this vaccine, the interest has been so low," rues a doctor at Delhi's LNJP Hospital.

Even timely screening is a rarity in India. "This cancer is very commonly detected in an advanced stage because of this," says Dr Nidhi Nayyar, Consultant, Gynaecologic Surgical Oncology & Robotic Surgery, BLK Max Super Speciality Hospital. "Many women don't come for screening or check-ups even when they see symptoms like post-menopausal bleeding, which should be an immediate cause for alarm. There is a lot of shyness and fear of people finding out about their private lives."

In many cases, by the time a person decides to seek help, it's too late. "If you come very early, then you can avoid chemotherapy," says Dr Lalit Kumar, chairperson, Oncology & BMT, Artemis Hospitals, and former head of the department of medical oncology at AIIMS Delhi. "Though, even then, this is not an easy cancer. For those who are yet to have children, it means you won't be able to do so any longer. The surgery itself is quite a big one and recovery takes time. That is why if one can prevent cancer altogether, there is no reason to get to this stage at all." Symptoms in the early stages may include disturbance in the menstrual cycle, intermittent bleeding between periods, vaginal discharge, post-coital bleeding or pain, and lower abdominal pain. The treatment may require surgery for the removal of the uterus, cervix and the tumour, without any need for radiation.

However, once the cancer progresses, it can lead to obstruction of the kidneys, recurrent urinary infections, distended abdomen, among other problems. It can also infect other organs and lead to tumours. And this is where intensive treatment methods like radiation come in, along with mounting expenses. For early treatment itself, various